

TutorVista Using Open Source in Digital Education

TutorVista, a digital tutoring website, uses open source software to mimic a classroom experience and maintain its database.



The TutorVista team

TutorVista is an online tutoring service that was founded in 2005. Its operations are entirely located in India, but most of its market is abroad. The company primarily provides academic help to students residing in the US, in subjects like English, mathematics and the sciences.

How it works

TutorVista has provided over 6,500,000 live tutoring sessions over the past six years. The website provides one-on-one training to students through the Internet. Its goal is to make the entire online tutoring experience seem as if the students are in the session, physically, while taking advantage of tutoring skills from all over the world, especially India. Students in the US sign up for a minimum number of hours, log in to the website, and choose a subject they want to get tutored in. The tutors, primarily from India, log in to a different portal when they are ready to start taking tutoring sessions. "We check the availability of the tutor for the requested subject in real-time, and make sure they are both connected together," explains G Ramasubramani, CTO, TutorVista. If the tutor is not available, students are given options from available time slots. Once

the student and tutor are connected, they use a white-board technology on their screen as the main medium of communication, along with chat and Voice over Internet Protocol (VoIP).

The students put forward their queries, and the tutors respond with explanations that use the white-board as a teaching aid. "We try to mimic a classroom experience as much as we can, by using the white-board we developed and enhanced. Its design is based on feedback we received from our tutors and students over the past few years," Ramasubramani reveals. This allows the tutor and student to exchange information as if they are writing on the same piece of paper. He illustrates this aspect with an example, "If a student cannot solve a math problem, he shows the tutor how he answered the question by either uploading the answer paper or writing it on the white-board. The tutor takes a look at the steps and checks where the student went wrong. He then uses the white-board to show the student how to solve the problem, and in the process he helps the student understand some of the concepts. It is more about using questions as a trigger to get where you want to go." Ramasubramani observes that tutors are often more comfortable offering explanations by